launched; simultaneously the JKLF (a freedom-seeking secular group) was sidelined by the more radical pro-Pakistan Hizb-ul-Mujahideen. [7]

With Indian troops soon flooding the valley, many of whom had no idea of how to battle this new challenge, there were excesses committed that continue to plague the Kashmiris. One such case that still awaits closure is of the allegations of mass rape committed by Indian troops on the night of 23–24 February 1991 of at least 100 women of the twin villages of Kunan Poshpora. Several fact-finding missions—by civil servants, the army, and even NGOs—have led nowhere, as the statements of the victims (and their numbers) have been inconsistent. The only consistent fact is that none of those claiming to be rape survivors has accused an Indian Army officer of misconduct. Nevertheless, the considerable public outrage and condemnation of the Indian Army put enormous pressure on its soldiers, who were now battling militants and the public at large. But even then, as the militancy began to lose its momentum, Pakistan started pushing its veterans from its recent adventure in Afghanistan to lead the insurgency and scale up its military activities. By mid-1990s, the Hizb-ul-Mujahideen was sidelined by the Lashkar-e-Taiba, which still enjoys wide support amongst Pakistanis. Simultaneously, Pakistan also extended support for setting up All Parties Hurriyat Conference, a coalition of 26 anti-India political parties in March 1993 to keep raising the cause of Kashmiri separatism. But, they were a divided lot with Syed Ali Shah Geelani, a hardliner, and Mirwaiz Farooq, a moderate, leading the two groups. Over the years, Pakistani leaders visiting India insisted on engaging with them, promising them that ‘freedom’ was around the corner. Pakistani intelligence agencies funnelled money to the conference’s leaders, as investigations have now revealed, to keep the fires burning.

Al-Fatah Rises from the Grave

Away from the spotlight of the insurgency, in the spring of 1988, eight years after his rehabilitation and while working in his government job, Fazl-ul-Haq Qureshi, the veteran of the struggles of the Master Cell and Al-Fatah,